PSYCHOLOGICAL/COGNITIVE FALSE BELIEF #73 · SUBSTANCE ABUSE

“I’ve earned it. After what I’ve been through, I deserve the relief.”

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Where it often comes from

If you have suffered, relief can feel like something you are owed. A hard childhood, a loss, a body in pain, a mind that will not rest: of course you want the pain to stop. Wanting relief is not selfish. The lie is narrower. It says this particular use is the relief you have earned, and that you should not question it because of what you have been through. You can honor the pain and still tell the truth that this kind of relief is hurting you. God is not stingy with comfort. He does not say you must keep hurting. He offers rest that does not master you. If you want help, call the SAMHSA National Helpline at 1-800-662-4357. Do not try to stop or withdraw on your own if that could make you sick. A doctor can help you do it safely, and a counselor can walk with you. Needing that help is not a failure.

What Scripture teaches

Jesus says, “Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest.” The invitation is for tired people, not for people who have already coped correctly. The Lord is near the brokenhearted. You can come for mercy and find grace to help. He will strengthen and help you. His mercies are new every morning. These verses do not scold you for wanting relief. They say the rest He gives is better than a relief that starts to own you.

> *“Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest”* (Matthew 11:28).

Also see

> “The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit” (Psalm 34:18).

> “Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need” (Hebrews 4:16).

> “Do not fear, for I am with you; do not be afraid, for I am your God. I will strengthen you; I will surely help you; I will uphold you with My right hand of righteousness” (Isaiah 41:10).

> “Because of the loving devotion of the LORD we are not consumed, for His mercies never fail. They are new every morning; great is Your faithfulness!” (Lamentations 3:22–23).

Common self-statements

- After what I have been through, I deserve this.
- Anyone in my place would use.
- If I stop, I am refusing myself the only kindness I get.
- God does not understand how tired I am.
- Comfort that comes with a cost is still mine to keep.
- People who tell me to get help do not know what I have survived.

Common logical errors

- Emotional reasoning: Feeling you have earned it and treating the feeling as the whole truth.
- All-or-nothing thinking: Either you get this relief or you get no comfort at all.
- Discounting the positive: Ignoring every other comfort because this one is faster.
- Justification: Using real pain as a reason not to look at real cost.

Challenging questions

- What pain am I trying to quiet, and is it allowed to matter?
- Has this relief stayed kind, or has it started to cost me?
- What comfort have I decided does not count?
- Would I want rest for a friend that begins to master them?
- What would Jesus' "I will give you rest" look like besides this?
- Who can help me pursue comfort without shaming the pain?

Truth summary

> I am allowed to want relief after what I have been through. Using is not the only comfort God has for me.

Related Pearls topics

Click a topic to open it in the Pearls Scripture Search:

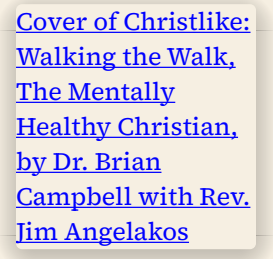
- Suffering
- Sorrow
- Joy
- Help
- Love, By God

Godly Counsel Lessons:

From the book *Godly Counsel* by Dr. Brian Campbell. Click a lesson to open it. You can read it on screen or print it.

- Suffering
- Depression
- Prayer

What does a mentally healthy Christian look like?



From *Christlike: Walking the Walk* by Dr. Brian Campbell. A portrait, verse by verse, of how a mentally healthy Christian thinks, feels, and lives.

Read excerpts from "The Mentally Healthy Christian" (with every Scripture written out)

Listen: Overcoming Anxiety

Overcoming Anxiety · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 18 minutes

Listen: Overcoming Depression

Overcoming Depression · Dr. Brian Campbell · about 20 minutes

Songs that speak truth to this belief

This Is Amazing Grace — Phil Wickham
Grace is real relief. It does not have to come in a bottle or a pill.

Amazing Grace My Chains Are Gone — Chris Tomlin
Mercy can loosen what you reached for when you were hurting.

East to West — Casting Crowns
God's kindness runs toward you. You do not have to earn a harmful kind of relief.

Amazing Grace — Reawaken Hymns
Amazing grace is for people who have been through hard things, not only for people who coped well.

Each morning ask: "If I truly believed God's truth instead of this lie, what is one step I could take today?"

HOMEWORK · REPLACE AND REHEARSE

My Plan for Replacing "I've earned it. After what I've been through, I deserve the relief."

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Read through each section and check the one that fits you best. If none of them fit, write your own. One choice per section is enough. A truth you choose for yourself will stick better than one handed to you.

Name: _____ Date started: _____

1 How strongly do I believe the lie?

Rate it now so you can see your progress later.

"I've earned it. After what I've been through, I deserve the relief." I believe this _____ % (0 = not at all, 100 = completely)

2 My best question

The one question I will ask myself every time the lie shows up.

- ☐ What pain am I trying to quiet, and is it allowed to matter?
- ☐ Has this relief stayed kind, or has it started to cost me?
- ☐ What comfort have I decided does not count?
- ☐ Would I want rest for a friend that begins to master them?
- ☐ What would Jesus' "I will give you rest" look like besides this?
- ☐ Who can help me pursue comfort without shaming the pain?

My own question: _____

3 My replacement truth

The statement I will say to myself instead of the lie.

- ☐ I am allowed to want relief after what I have been through. Using is not the only comfort God has for me.
- ☐ Wanting the pain to ease is human and good.
- ☐ What I have suffered is real.
- ☐ A harmful relief is not the only kindness available to me.
- ☐ Jesus invites weary people to rest.
- ☐ I can seek comfort and still be honest about the cost.

In my own words: _____

4 My Scripture

The verse that speaks most directly to me. This is the one I will memorize.

- ☐ Matthew 11:28
  "Come to Me, all you who are weary and burdened, and I will give you rest."
- ☐ Psalm 34:18
  "The LORD is near to the brokenhearted; He saves the contrite in spirit."
- ☐ Hebrews 4:16
  "Let us then approach the throne of grace with confidence, so that we may receive mercy and find grace to help us in our time of need."

A verse I found myself: _____

Practicing the Truth

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5 My practice plan

Everyone does the first four. Then pick one or two extra tools.

EVERYONE DOES THESE

- [ ] Make my Truth Card (below). Carry it and read it at least three times a day.
- [ ] Memorize my Scripture from Step 4.
- [ ] Listen to one song each day from "Songs that speak truth to this belief" on my card, and fill in my song journal (below).
- [ ] Set reminders to silently repeat my truth. Check one or more:
  - ☐ A buzz: my watch or phone vibrates every _____ minutes
  - ☐ An everyday event: every time I _____
  - ☐ A visual reminder: something I will see often, such as a sticky note on my mirror, my truth as the background picture on my phone, or a note on my car dashboard.

PICK ONE OR TWO THAT FIT ME

- [ ] When you felt you had earned it: Each day, write down one moment when you called using the relief you deserved. Write what happened, what you told yourself, and one more accurate statement.
- [ ] My name in Scripture: Write a personal reminder based on my verse and read it aloud. Keep this application separate from the Bible quotation.

  For example, Matthew 11:28 becomes: "James can write: "I am weary, and Jesus offers rest. This is not my only comfort.""
- [ ] Gratitude journal: Each night, write three things I thank God for.
- [ ] Truth recording: Record my own voice reading my Truth Card and verse, and listen in the car or on a walk.
- [ ] Reading: The "Suffering" topic in Pearls.
- [ ] Listening: The Overcoming Anxiety audio or the Overcoming Depression audio by Dr. Brian Campbell. Tap to play.

6 My action step this week

Do one thing that tests the lie in real life.

Choose steps you can do safely. If this belief comes with hopelessness or thoughts of ending your life, call or text 988 (the Suicide & Crisis Lifeline), or call 911 in an emergency. For help with substance use, call 1-800-662-4357, and talk with a doctor before you stop if withdrawal could make you sick.

- [ ] Name the pain and the cost on two lines. The pain is allowed to be real. The cost is allowed to be real too.
- [ ] Ask for one other comfort this week: a safe person, a meeting, prayer, or a call to 1-800-662-4357.
- [ ] Do not stop suddenly to prove you do not need the relief. Talk with a doctor about a safe plan.
- [ ] Pray Matthew 11:28 as a tired person, not as someone who must first deserve rest.

What I will do: _____

When: _____

What the lie predicts will happen: _____

7 End-of-week check-in

Bring this page to your next session.

What actually happened: _____

_____

What I learned: _____

The lie "I've earned it. After what I've been through, I deserve the relief.": _____ % My truth: _____ %

Daily practice tracker

Day	Read my card	Said my verse	Used my reminder	A comfort that was not using
Mon				
Tue				
Wed				
Thu				
Fri				
Sat				
Sun				

My song journal

After each day's song, write what it told you that challenges the lie.

Day	Song I listened to	What it told me that challenges the lie
Mon		
Tue		
Wed		
Thu		
Fri		
Sat		
Sun		

My Truth Card

THE LIE

~~I've earned it. After what I've been through, I deserve the relief~~

THE TRUTH

GOD'S WORD

Copy onto a 3×5 card, or cut along the dashed line and carry it with you.

Prayer

Lord, I have called this the relief I earned. I am weary. Give me the rest You promised, and a safe way to seek comfort that does not master me. Amen.

Scripture quotations are from the Berean Standard Bible (BSB), which is in the public domain.